

Case Helper

Build your Small Claims case from your evidence.

SMU LIT Legal-Tech Hackathon 2026. Problem statement 4, MinLaw: people at the Small Claims Tribunals with no lawyer.

Team: [TEAM NAME]

Live: case-helper-production.up.railway.app Code: github.com/jemeryy/LIT-hackathon

The problem

At the Small Claims Tribunals you cannot bring a lawyer. You prepare the case yourself. So people ask ChatGPT. It agrees with them, makes up cases, and does not know the court's steps.

They turn up with a story and no proof, or the wrong proof, and lose on the facts.

The Courts' guide on generative AI says the person is responsible for what they file. Nothing helps them meet that duty.

What they need is not legal advice. It is a way to sort their own evidence and see what the other side will say.

What we built: five steps, one page

1. Tell us what happened. A chat in your own words. The model pulls out the facts and asks for what is missing.
2. Can the tribunal hear it? Four rule checks, each quoting the section of the Act.
3. Your evidence. Add files, see what else to gather, answer what the other side may have, then rank both sides.
4. Your timeline. Past events from your files, then the court's steps ahead and the time bar date.
5. What to do next. In the court's own order, with a claim pack ready to paste into the filing portal.

Case Helper for the Small Claims Tribunals Mei Ling [New case](#)

Step 1 of 5

Tell us what happened

Tell me what happened, in your own words. Who is the other side? What did you agree? What went wrong, and when? How much do you want back? I will ask if anything is missing.

My landlord Mr Tan will not return my \$2,600 deposit. I rented his flat for 12 months and moved out on 31 Jul 2026. He said ok, all good. Then on 15 Aug 2026 he said the sofa was scratched and refused to pay it back.

You say your landlord kept your \$2,600 deposit. What is your full name and address? What is the landlord's full name and Singapore address?

I am Mei Ling, Blk 123 Bedok North Street 1 #05-67, Singapore 460123. He is Tan Ah Kow, 45 Bedok Reservoir Road #12-34, Singapore 470045. Yes, he lives in Singapore.

You say both addresses are in Singapore. Was the flat your home, and how long was the lease? When was the deposit due under the agreement?

Yes, an HDB flat I lived in. 12 months, 3 Aug 2025 to 2 Aug 2026. One month deposit, returned within 14 days after I move out, minus any damage.

You say the flat was your home under a 12-month lease. Add the agreement, messages, payment record, photos, and video in step 3.

Type here. Enter sends. Shift and Enter starts a new line.

[Back](#) [Start over](#) [Send](#) [Next](#)

This tool does not give legal advice. You are responsible for what you file. Check every rule yourself on Singapore Statutes Online.

Works for a real case today: tenancy deposit, goods, services, damage to property. Not only the demo.

Step 2: rules, not a model

Type of claim, amount, time bar, other side in Singapore.

Each check quotes the section from Singapore Statutes Online, with the date we fetched it.

Same answer every time. Fail a check and it stops and points to the right place.

Work claims, loans and neighbour noise are turned away here, before any file is read.

Case Helper for the Small Claims Tribunals

Mei Ling New case

1 Tell us what happened
Done

2 Can the tribunal hear it?
You are here

3 Your evidence

4 Your timeline

5 What to do next

Step 2 of 5

Can the Small Claims Tribunals hear this?

Four checks from the law, using what you told us.

Pass

The tribunal hears this kind of claim: a dispute under a home lease of 2 years or less.

[Read the rule](#)

Pass

You are claiming \$2,600. The limit is \$20,000, or \$30,000 if both sides agree.

[Read the rule](#)

Pass

The problem started on 15 Aug 2026, the day the landlord refused or the loss happened. You have 2 years from that day, so until 15 Aug 2028.

[Read the rule](#)

Pass

The landlord is in Singapore, so the claim can be served.

[Read the rule](#)

The details entered match all four checks below.

Back

Step 2 of 5

Next

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Step 3: your evidence, ranked from the files

Every fact carries an exact quote. We match the quote back into the file. No match, the fact is dropped.

Press a row and the file opens at that page, with the line highlighted.

A file whose names, dates or amounts do not fit your account is marked weak and kept out of the story.

What else to gather: five headings for your kind of claim, what you have and what is still missing.

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Your evidence

A. Add your files
Agreement, chat screenshots, bank transfer, photos or video. Only files count as evidence.

Your evidence

E1 Tenancy agreementRead, 6 pagesE2 WhatsApp screenshotsRead, 6 filesE3 Email from the landlordReadE4 Deposit transfer screenshotReadE5 Move-out videoReadE6 Move-in photosRead, 5 filesE7 WhatsApp_Evidence_ChatLog_PetBreach.pdfRead, 1 pageAdd a file

The other side's evidence (added under C below)
No files yet.

B. What else to gather
Based on your kind of claim and the files you added. Add a file under each heading.

Messages and calls
The other side's own words, dated, are the strongest thing you can bring.
You have

- Landlord wrote "ok, all good" at handover, 31 Jul (E2)
- Landlord says sofa damaged, 15 Aug (E2)
- Landlord says sofa damaged, 15 Aug (E3)
- File concerns different parties, unit, and a pet breach, not Mei Ling's deposit claim (E7)

Still missing

- The full chat export, in order
- Any voice note or call log
- Anything agreed face to face: date, words, who was there

Add a file

The agreement
The agreement sets what each side must do.
You have

- Deposit \$2,600, refund within 14 days of moving out, less damage (E1)
- Lease of 12 months from 3 Aug 2025, signed by both (E1)
- Clause 6 says an inventory list is signed at handover (E1)

Still missing

- Inventory list signed at handover, if your agreement has one
- Stamp duty certificate (the court asks for it) by both (E1)
- Property listing, if it described the furniture

Add a file

Payments
Shows what you paid and what you still owe, if anything.
You have

- Deposit \$2,600 paid 3 Aug 2025 (E4)

Still missing

- Last month's rent transfer
- Final utility bill and receipt
- Any repair invoice they sent you

Add a file

Photos and video
Dated pictures of the flat before and after are the answer to a damage claim.
You have

- Flat condition when you left (E5)
- Flat condition when you moved in (E6)

Still missing

- Dated move-in photos or video of the rooms and furniture
- Handover form
- Cleaner or mover receipt

Add a file

Your letter asking for the money
The tribunal expects you to have asked first, in writing, with a date to reply by.
E7 WhatsApp_Evidence_ChatLog_PetBreach.pdfRead, 1 pageAdd a file

You have

- WhatsApp_Evidence_ChatLog_PetBreach.pdf (E7)

Still missing

- A written request to the landlord for the deposit with a reply date. You can make one on the last step.

BackStep 3 of 5Next

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The other side's evidence: the confirmation bias fix

Seven yes / no / not sure questions about what the other side could bring.

Their list, ranked for them, with why it is strong and how to answer it from your own files.

We never argue their case. We list what they could show so the person is not surprised at the first hearing.

A file you have of theirs goes in their column, never in yours.

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Your evidence

Write down their name. You can name them as a witness later.

YesNoNot sure

Add a file

If yes, say how much and when. It changes the amount you claim.

YesNoNot sure

Add a file

6 of 6 answered.

The landlord can make a claim back against you, up to 3 days before the first court meeting. Your evidence list is your answer to it.

Your story

You rented Mr Tan's flat for 12 months and paid a \$2,600 deposit on 3 Aug 2025. You moved out on 31 Jul 2026 and he wrote "ok, all good". On 15 Aug he refused to return the deposit, saying the sofa was damaged.

D. Your evidence, strongest first

Press a row to see the file.

Rank	What it shows	Source	How strong	Why
1	Deposit \$2,600, refund within 14 days of moving out, less damage	E1 cl. 4, p.2	Strong	Signed by both of you, has amount and dates
2	Deposit \$2,600 paid 3 Aug 2025	E4	Strong	Bank record, third party, Read from a screenshot, check it
3	Landlord wrote "ok, all good" at handover, 31 Jul	E2 shot 4	Medium	His own words, dated, in your chat screenshot. Read from a screenshot, check it
4	Flat condition when you left	E5 video, 1:12	Medium	Filmed by you on 31 Jul, sofa shown at 1:12
5	Landlord says sofa damaged, 15 Aug	E2 shot 5, E3	Medium	His claim in chat and email, no photo sent. Read from a screenshot, check it
6	Flat condition when you moved in	E6 photo 1	Weak	No date stamp, sofa not in any photo

E. The other side's evidence, strongest first

From your answers above. Nothing here is proof. It is what they could bring, so you are ready for it.

Rank	What they may show	Source	How strong for them	Why	How to answer
1	A repair or cleaning invoice	Your answer: Yes	Strong	A signed paper or your own words. Hard to argue with.	Your move-in and move-out photos of the same item, and any wear and tear clause in the agreement.
2	Your own words accepting a deduction	Your answer: Yes	Strong	A signed paper or your own words. Hard to argue with.	The full message thread around that point, so the words are read in order.
3	Photos of the flat or furniture taken after you left	Your answer: Yes	Medium	Real, but your own dated files can answer it.	Your own dated move-out photos or video of the same rooms and items.
4	The inventory or handover form you signed Not sure	Your answer: Not sure	Medium	Real, but your own dated files can answer it. You are not sure they have it, so one step weaker.	Your copy of the form, plus dated photos of the item at move-in and move-out.
5	Messages or words showing other conditions you agreed to	Your answer: Yes	Medium	Real, but your own dated files can answer it.	The messages where each condition was set and where you met it, in date order.
6	A witness to the handover	Your answer: Yes	Weak	One person's word. Easy to question.	Your own witness, if anyone was with you. Their name and what they saw.

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Steps 4 and 5: the road ahead

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2Can the tribunal hear it?Done

3Your evidenceDone

4Your timelineYou are here

5What to do next

Step 4 of 5

Your timeline

Black dots come from your files. Dotted circles are steps still to come. Press a dot to read more.

3 Aug 2025Lease starts, deposit paid (E1, E4)

31 Jul 2026Move out, "all good" (E2, E5)

14 Aug 2026Refund due (E1 cl. 4, p.2)

15 Aug 2026Landlord refuses (E2, E3)

6 Sep 2026Today

next

File your claim online

Give the other side a copy

First court meeting

Hearing

15 Aug 2028Time bar

3 Aug 2025: Lease starts, deposit paid (E1, E4)

Deposit \$2,600, refund within 14 days of moving out, less damage ("The Landlord shall refund the deposit within 14 days after the Tenant moves out"). Lease of 12 months from 3 Aug 2025, signed by both ("for a term of 12 months starting on 3 August 2025"). Deposit \$2,600 paid 3 Aug 2025 ("Transfer of SGD 2,600.00 to TAN AH KOW"). [Open E1 cl. 4, p.2](#) or [Open E1 cl. 1, p.2](#) or [Open E4](#)

Last day to file

15 Aug 2028

2 years after 15 Aug 2026, the day the landlord refused or the loss happened. You must file by then.

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Step 4 of 5

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What to do next

Start with number 1.

1. Send a letter asking for the deposit

Give the landlord 7 days to reply. The letter uses only your facts and your agreement.

Open the letter

2. Gather what is missing

Stamp duty certificate, signed inventory list, final bill, dated move-in photos.

See the list

3. Do the check on the court website

Answer a few questions on the court website. It gives you a number. Use it within 7 days.

Court website

4. Fill the claim form and pay

Log in with Singpass. Fill in your details, the other side, the claim, and a short summary. Upload your files as PDF. Then pick a date for the first court meeting. The fee is \$10.

Court guide

5. Give the landlord a copy within 7 working days

Download the copy for the landlord. Hand it to them or send it by registered post. Then tell the court you have done so.

Court guide

6. Before the first court meeting

The landlord may offer to settle online. Fill in the court form: what happened in date order, and any witnesses. Bring your files in the order of your evidence list.

Court guide

Your evidence list

A list of every file, in order. Opens in Excel. Add rows as you gather more.

Download the list

Your claim pack

Everything the online claim form asks for, ready to copy and upload. You still file it yourself.

Download the pack

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Step 5 of 5

Next

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Timeline: events from the files, today, then the court's steps and the 2 year time bar. Maps onto the court's Submission for Hearing form.

Next steps in the court's order: written request, pre-filing assessment, the six part claim form with a 500 character summary, \$10 fee, serve within 7 working days.

Downloads: an evidence sheet (xlsx), a written request, and a claim pack with the form text and every file as a PDF under 5 MB.

Where the model stops and the rules start

The model does

Reads what you type and fills the form

Reads each file and returns facts with exact quotes

Writes the story, the 500 character summary and the request letter

Rules do

The four gate checks

Strength and rank of every fact

What else to gather, the other side's list

Timeline, fee, next steps

Nobody does

No case names, ever

No guess at who wins

No legal advice

No invented evidence

No file leaves your case

Every quote is matched into the file or dropped. Legal conclusions and advice words from the model are rejected by the server. File text, names and chat are treated as data, never as instructions.

The person is told on every page: this tool does not give legal advice, you are responsible for what you file, check every rule on Singapore Statutes Online.

What is real and what is stubbed

Real

Chat intake, file reading (PDF, screenshots, photos, one video frame), quotes matched and highlighted, the gate, both rankings, gather list, timeline, fee, next steps, evidence sheet, request letter, claim pack. Live now on Railway.

Stubbed

Filing on the court's portal (CJTS). There is no public API, so the claim pack is what you paste and upload yourself.

Statute text is only the sections the gate quotes, plus the court's guide. Not all of Singapore law.

Data

The demo files are made up by us. No real documents were used at any point.

AI tools used (disclosure)

To build it

Claude Code (Anthropic), with Claude Opus and Fable models, for planning, code, browser testing and this deck.

OpenAI Codex, for a second opinion on each plan and a review of each change.

Playwright, driven by Claude Code, for end to end tests in a real browser.

Inside the product

Claude Sonnet 5 through OpenRouter (anthropic/claude-sonnet-5), with the hackathon credits.

Design decisions

Every design call was the team's, recorded in the plan file and the commit history in the repo. We can explain every line.

References

Law and court sources

Small Claims Tribunals Act 1984, s 2, s 5, s 23 and the Schedule. Singapore Statutes Online, sso.agc.gov.sg/Act/SCTA1984, read 5 Sep 2026.

State Courts, A Guide to Small Claims (PDF), judiciary.gov.sg. Fees, service, e-Negotiation, appeal.

Judiciary pages: File a small claim; How to file and serve a small claim. Community Justice and Tribunals System, cjts.judiciary.gov.sg.

Registrar's Circular No. 1 of 2024, Guide on the Use of Generative AI Tools by Court Users, in force 1 Oct 2024.

Libraries and tools

FastAPI, Uvicorn, python-multipart, httpx, Anthropic Python SDK, pdfplumber, PyMuPDF, Pillow, pillow-heif, pytesseract with Tesseract OCR, openpyxl, reportlab, ffmpeg, python-pptx.

Data

Synthetic sample pack made by the team ([builds/case-builder/sample](#)). No organiser or real data.

What we would build next

Keep cases and files across restarts, so a person can come back a week later.

Own content sets for services and damage to property, then the other claim types in the Schedule.

Prepare the person for e-Negotiation on CJTS: the five rounds of offers.

Test it with Community Justice Centre volunteers on real, consented cases.

Ask us anything. We built every part and can show the code.